

mail of the week

misguided youths for defaming the whole community by their unholy acts. To stop it, people believing in the faith should come forward to condemn the activities of the disgruntled elements. They should show their greatness and wisdom by dousing the flames which always get flared up due to the misdeeds of a few youngsters. **DILBAG RAI, Chandigarh**

Ram Vilas Paswan wants the Government to give citizenship to 25 million Bangladeshis, who are already staying in India ("Politics of Terror", September 29). Do politicians like Paswan even realise the consequences of making such irresponsible statements and following a policy of minority appeasement? Only votes matter to them. Can't our politicians be a little more reasonable and practical in their approach and think of the people and their welfare, if nothing else? **ATUL MARATHE, on e-mail**

Green Saviour

Ajit Pattnaik's efforts in conserving the pangolin, a rare and reclusive mammal, are truly commendable. ("Saving Private Pangolin", September 29). People like him can surely inspire others to do their bit in saving many such rare species from extinction. **BRINDA UPADHYAYA, on e-mail**

Stating Truth

It is good to know that Punjab is ranked the best state (State of the States", September 22). But it is a matter of great sorrow that it has such a poor sex ratio.

The process of development is incomplete if the state fails to guarantee better life to its fairer sex. **MAHBOOB UL HAQUE, on e-mail**

Some of the legislators contest elections, win and then occupy a place of pride in Parliament and assemblies, with just one goal in mind—their own welfare ("Shackled by Sloth", September 22). These MPs and MLAs rarely work for the people whom they represent. People must elect

only those candidates who have a track record of commitment and integrity, irrespective of their party affiliations.

ARUN GANESH, on e-mail

Adding It Up

Perfetti Van Melle India seeks to clarify that the commercial on Center Fruit has been amended, but not withdrawn as mentioned in your article ("Ad Policing", September 29).

HARSH ARORA, director, Perfetti Van Melle India

SHADES OF SECULARISM



Having succeeded in creating a divide among the two communities, the Hindus and the Muslims, the saffron clan—VHP, RSS, Bajrang Dal and to top it all BJP—is now pursuing their next agenda, creating chaos and mayhem with their violent attacks on Christians and their places of worship, in Orissa, Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka ("For God's Sake", September 22). Instead of remaining a mute spectator to brutal carnage against the Christians, the Central Government should swing into action. The state governments should be dismissed with immediate effect for their failure in protecting the lives of the hapless Christians, and President's rule be imposed.

THARCUS S. FERNANDO, Chennai

If the Government banned SIMI, dubbing it a terror group, why is it scared of banning saffron outfits like the Bajrang Dal and the VHP?

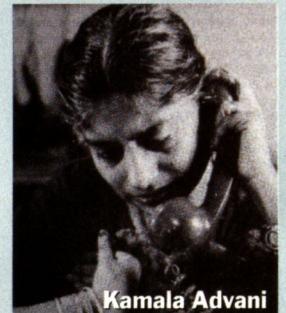
PRIYA RANJAN, Bhatinda

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30

Years Ago in India Today
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Power Behind the Throne

Behind every successful man, so the old saying goes, there is a woman manipulating invisible strings that control everything from his professional destiny to his diet. The wives of a majority of the current crop of cabinet ministers bear ample testimony to that. Ministers' wives, for the most part, live highly sequestered and sterile lives, shielded from the contaminating clutches of the common herd, and elbowed into domestic obscurity by the fawning sycophants who constantly dog the ministers' footsteps. While there are obviously no Jacqueline Kennedys or Eleanor Roosevelts among the present list of ministers' wives, there are some exceptions to the rule. Notably Lalla Fernandes, wife of the industry minister and pretty much of a firebrand in her own right. But Kamala Advani, wife of the information and broadcasting minister, surprisingly avoids watching TV ("I have no time for it"). She has a no nonsense air about her and gives the impression of being quietly efficient. She's more interested in running her house than in her husband's affairs.

—Pamela Sehgal

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